Polling data underscore this divide: While 73 percent of US Democrats and left-leaning independents believe scientists should have an active role in policy decisions, only 43 percent of populist-aligned supporters share this view.[7] This trend is not limited to the United States, as trust in scientific expertise is generally higher among nonpopulist constituencies globally.[8]

Beyond withholding data, populists often degrade domestic institutions that produce them. Budget cuts, staff dismissals, and the replacement of technocrats with loyalists are common practices that diminish the ability of bureaucracies to collect and analyze scientific information. Examples abound. Populist president Andrés Manuel Lopez Obrador slashed funding for Mexico's scientific institutions, framing them as part of the "golden bureaucracy"; Bolivia's Evo Morales reduced investment in research institutions, viewing science primarily as a tool to serve nationalist ends; Donald Trump dismissed scientific advisors, reduced budgets for agencies like the Environmental Protection Agency, and spread misinformation contrary to established scientific findings; and Brazil's Jair Bolsonaro purged environmental agencies of scientists monitoring deforestation in the Amazon. These actions disrupt the production of reliable data, leaving IOs with incomplete or inaccurate information, which undermines their ability to address global challenges effectively.

To assess the relationship between populism and missing data, we analyze the World Bank's World Development Indicators (WDI), focusing on two domains: environment and public health. The Bank relies heavily on data from member states to monitor environmental impacts, evaluate project outcomes, and address public health crises. Missing data in these domains can signal a deliberate lack of cooperation.

We calculate the share of missing scientific indicators in the WDI for each country in each year, standardizing the results for interpretation. Our key independent variable is the populism indicator from Funke, Schularick, and Trebesch (2023), and we again control for variables such as democracy levels, economic capacity (GDP per capita), and IMF program participation. Our models include country- and year-fixed effects to account for unobservable factors, with standard errors clustered by country.[9]